

Document 23: Student Council Constitution & Election Regulations

Institution: Hyderabad Institute of Technology (HIT)

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1. Preamble and Structure of the Student Body

The Student Council of Hyderabad Institute of Technology serves as the sole recognized democratic bridge between the student population and the university leadership. Its primary mandate is to advocate for student welfare, organize campus-wide intellectual and cultural initiatives, and represent student perspectives on institutional committees.

The Student Council operates under the administrative oversight of the Dean of Student Affairs. The governing body consists of the Executive Board and the Class Representative Assembly:

- **The Executive Board:** Composed of six elected officers—President, Vice-President, General Secretary, Treasurer, Cultural Secretary, and Sports Secretary.
- **The Class Representative (CR) Assembly:** Composed of one elected Class Representative from every registered academic section across all departments and years.

The Student Council is strictly an autonomous student body; it does not hold executive veto power over institutional academic rules, fee structures, or disciplinary penalties enacted by the University Senate.

2. Voter Eligibility vs. Candidacy Eligibility

The university maintains a fundamental distinction between the right to vote in campus elections and the right to stand as a candidate for public office.

Voter Eligibility (Universal Student Suffrage): Every undergraduate student with an active enrollment status and an active university identity card holds the legal right to cast a ballot in the general student elections. There are no minimum CGPA cutoffs, attendance requirements, or disciplinary disqualifications that can strip an enrolled student of their right to vote.

Candidacy Eligibility (Rigidly Gatekept): To ensure that student leaders maintain strong academic focus and set a positive behavioral example, running for office is subject to strict statutory prerequisites evaluated at the time of nomination:

- **The Presidency:** Open exclusively to students entering their seventh semester (fourth-year undergraduate). The presidential candidate must possess a minimum Cumulative Grade Point Average (CGPA) of 8.0, zero lifetime academic backlogs, and a minimum 80% aggregate attendance across all prior years.
- **Vice-President and General Secretary:** Open to students entering their fifth semester (third-year undergraduate). Candidates must possess a minimum CGPA of 7.5 and zero active backlogs at the time of filing nomination papers.
- **Secretaries (Cultural, Sports, and Treasury):** Open to second and third-year students maintaining a minimum CGPA of 7.0 and not more than one cleared backlog.
- **Class Representatives (CR):** Open to any student within that specific section who has a minimum CGPA of 6.5 and zero active disciplinary warnings.

Any candidate with a recorded disciplinary strike from the Disciplinary Action Committee (DAC) or the Anti-Ragging Committee is permanently disqualified from ever running for any Student Council position.

3. Ban on External Political Affiliations

HIT enforces a strictly apolitical campus environment in accordance with national educational directives (Lyngdoh Committee recommendations).

Student elections must remain focused entirely on campus-related student welfare, laboratory infrastructure, library services, and campus events.

- **External Affiliation Ban:** Candidates are explicitly prohibited from affiliating with, accepting endorsements from, or using the logos and flags of external political parties, national youth wings, religious organizations, or regional political outfits.
- **External Interference Penalty:** If a candidate is found inviting external political leaders to campus, accepting outside political funding, or organizing rallies outside the campus perimeter with political party banners, their nomination will be summarily canceled. The offending student will be handed over to the Disciplinary Action Committee for immediate suspension.

4. Election Timetable and Nomination Protocol

General student council elections are conducted once every academic year, precisely during the first week of September.

The Chief Election Officer (CEO), appointed by the Director of the Institute from senior non-partisan faculty members, issues the official Election Notification on the third Monday of August. The statutory election schedule runs as follows:

- **Day 1 to 3:** Submission of nomination forms along with academic transcripts, signed faculty advisor endorsements, and a mandatory ₹1,000 non-refundable security deposit.
- **Day 4:** Scrutiny and verification of nominations by the Election Commission.
- **Day 5:** Publication of the valid candidate list and a 24-hour window for voluntary withdrawal of nominations.
- **Day 6 to 9:** Official campaign window.
- **Day 10:** The Presidential Debate in the central auditorium, followed by a mandatory 24-hour campaign silence period.
- **Day 11:** Electronic voting day from 9:00 AM to 4:00 PM, with official result declaration by 7:00 PM the same evening.

5. Campaigning Rules and Strict Spending Caps

To ensure equal opportunity for all students regardless of personal financial background, the university imposes an absolute cap on campaign expenditures and restricts promotional mediums.

- **Financial Expenditure Cap:** A candidate running for the office of President is legally permitted to spend a maximum of ₹5,000 across their entire campaign. Candidates running for any other Executive Board position are capped at a maximum expenditure of ₹3,000.
- **Expense Audit:** Every candidate must submit a detailed expense ledger accompanied by original printed receipts to the Election Commission within 24 hours after voting concludes. Exceeding the spending cap by even one rupee results in instant disqualification and forfeiture of the win.
- **Physical Campaigning Restrictions:** Physical posters and handbills are restricted to designated "Election Notice Boards" in each academic block. Sticking campaign flyers on classroom walls, elevator doors, tree trunks, or bathroom mirrors is classified as campus defacement and attracts a ₹1,000 fine per occurrence. Printed flyers cannot exceed standard A4 paper size.
- **Digital Campaigning Guidelines:** Candidates may use social media channels and WhatsApp broadcast groups. However, mass unsolicited SMS blasting via paid commercial bulk-messaging gateways is strictly banned.

6. Electronic Voting Architecture and Result Certification

Voting at HIT is entirely digital, executed through the secure "HIT E-Vote" module embedded in the student portal.

On election day, voting terminals are set up in the central computer labs for day-scholars, while residential students may access the voting module from personal laptops connected to the campus HIT-SECURE Wi-Fi network.

- **Authentication:** The voting module uses Two-Factor Authentication (2FA). A student must authenticate using their LDAP login and submit a time-sensitive One-Time Password (OTP) sent to their registered mobile number.
- **Secrecy of Ballot:** The system uses zero-knowledge encryption algorithms. The system registers that a student has cast their ballot (preventing duplicate votes), but permanently severs the link between the student's ID and the specific candidate selected.
- **"None of the Above" (NOTA):** Every electronic ballot includes a mandatory NOTA option. If NOTA receives more than 50% of the total votes cast for a specific position, the election for that office is declared null and void, and a fresh round of nominations is conducted two weeks later.

7. The Impeachment and No-Confidence Protocol

Holding an elected office on the Student Council is a conditional privilege. An elected officer who fails to discharge their constitutional duties or engages in misconduct can be legally removed through a structured impeachment process.

An impeachment motion against any Executive Board member can be initiated under three specific circumstances: chronic absenteeism (missing three consecutive council meetings without written leave), drop in academic performance (CGPA falling below 6.5 during their tenure), or formal disciplinary charges.

The Impeachment Workflow:

1. **Motion Submission:** A formal Petition of No Confidence must be signed by at least one-third of the active Class Representative Assembly and submitted to the Dean of Student Affairs.
2. **Special Assembly Session:** Within seven working days, the Dean convenes a special session of the Class Representative Assembly where the accused officer is given thirty minutes to present a defense.
3. **Two-Thirds Majority Mandate:** A secret ballot vote is conducted among the Class Representatives. If two-thirds (66.7%) of the assembly votes in favor of the motion, the officer is immediately stripped of their title and badge.
4. **Succession:** In the event the President is successfully impeached, the Vice-President assumes the presidency for the remainder of the term. For any other vacant executive position, the council conducts an internal election within the Assembly to appoint an interim officer.